

Identifying a sentence

A main clause becomes a sentence once it starts with a capital letter and ends with a period, question mark, or exclamation point. All sentences must have a subject and a verb, and make sense without any additional information.

✗ the chef loves cooking

This is not a sentence because it does not begin with a capital letter and end with a period.

✓ The chef loves cooking.

What is.

This is not a sentence because it doesn't have a subject, nor does it make sense, and because the question word *what* at the beginning indicates that a question is being asked.

What is he cooking? ✓

✗ something is burning!

This is not a sentence because it does not start with a capital letter.

✓ Something is burning!

Commands

A command is a sentence that gives an order or an instruction. Instructions are most effective when they are written in simple sentences. The subject in a command is implied, rather than present—it is the person who is receiving the command. Orders usually end with an exclamation point, while instructions tend to end with a period.

This sentence gives an order, so it ends with an exclamation point.

Do not open the oven!

The implied subject is the person who is being told not to open the oven.

Please do not touch the pie.

The implied subject is the person who is being asked not to touch the pie.

This sentence gives a polite instruction, so it ends with a period.

Exclamations

An exclamation works in the same way as a statement, but it expresses a strong emotion, such as surprise or horror. Exclamations always end with an exclamation point.

The pie had exploded!

The use of an exclamation point instead of a period adds emotion to a statement, making it seem more dramatic.

The **shortest complete sentence** in the English language is “I am.”

REAL WORLD

“Careful you must be...”

When the simple rules of sentence construction are not followed, sentences become very hard to understand. The *Star Wars* character Yoda’s speech is a good example. Instead of speaking in sentences that follow the subject–verb–object pattern, Yoda muddles his sentences so that the object comes first, followed by the subject, and then the verb. The result is confusing.



GLOSSARY

Auxiliary verb A “helping” verb like *be* or *have* that joins the main verb in a sentence to the subject.

Main clause A group of words that contains a subject and a verb and makes complete sense on its own.

Object The person or thing that is receiving the action of the verb.

Subject The person or thing that is performing the action of the verb.